

What Makes Us, Us

January 4 - February 8, 2026

Overview

Summary:

United Methodists are often described by what we do, how we worship, or where we fall on a theological spectrum. But beneath all of that is something deeper. A theological imagination shaped by grace, sacrament, Scripture, the church, mystery, and a conviction that faith is meant to be lived.

What Makes Us, Us is a six-week series that explores the heart of Wesleyan theology, not as a system to memorize, but as a way of seeing God, ourselves, and the world. This series is about reclaiming our roots so we can better understand who we are and why our tradition still matters.

This is not about defending a denomination for its own sake. It is about naming the gifts we have been given and learning how to steward them faithfully.

Series Goal:

- To help the congregation understand the theological foundations of the Wesleyan tradition in a way that is accessible and practical. By the end of the series, worshipers should be able to articulate not only what Methodists believe, but why those beliefs shape how we live and love in the world.

Sermon Schedule

Sunday	Sermon Topic	Scripture
1/4/26	Outward and Visible	Acts 2:37–47, Matthew 28:16–20 1 Corinthians 11:23–26
1/11/26	Grace	Ephesians 2:1–10, Luke 15:11–32 Titus 3:3–8
1/18/26	The Bible	Luke 24:13–35, 2 Timothy 3:14–17 Nehemiah 8:1–12
1/25/26	The holy catholic church	1 Corinthians 12:12–27, Ephesians 4:1–16, Acts 2:42–47
2/1/26	Mystery	Romans 11:33–36, 1 Corinthians 13:9–12
2/8/26	Why It Matters	James 2:14–26, Matthew 25:31–46, Micah 6:6–8

Summaries of the sermons created by ChatGPT.

Week 1 | Outward and Visible | Acts 2:37–47, Matthew 28:16–20

This passage places baptism, teaching, fellowship, breaking of bread, and prayer at the center of the Church's shared life. The sacraments are not add-ons to belief but practices through which God's grace is encountered and the community is formed.

In the Wesleyan tradition, sacraments are outward and visible signs of inward and spiritual grace. God uses ordinary elements, water, bread, wine, to communicate extraordinary grace.

The sacraments are means of grace, not rewards for spiritual maturity. They remind us that faith is embodied, communal, and rooted in God's action before our response.

Week 2 | Grace | Ephesians 2:1–10, Luke 15:11–32

This passage traces the movement from death to life, from gift to purpose. Grace is the starting point of Wesleyan theology. Not human effort, not right belief, not moral achievement. Grace comes first.

John Wesley spoke of God's grace as active and persistent, reaching us before we ever reach for God, meeting us in our brokenness, and continuing to shape us throughout our lives. Grace is not just pardon for sin; it is God's ongoing work of healing and transformation.

This week explores prevenient, justifying, and sanctifying grace, not as technical categories, but as a lived reality that shapes how we understand salvation, holiness, and daily discipleship.

Week 3 | The Bible | Luke 24:13–35, 2 Timothy 3:14–17

On the road to Emmaus, Scripture is interpreted in community and recognized through lived encounter. The risen Christ teaches the disciples how to read the Bible as a unified story of God's redeeming work.

Wesley was deeply committed to Scripture, calling himself "a man of one book," yet he never treated the Bible as a flat text or a weapon.

In the Wesleyan tradition, Scripture is primary, but it is read through the lenses of tradition, reason, and experience. This week explores how Methodists read the Bible seriously, faithfully, and humbly. We will look at how Scripture forms us, challenges us, and draws us into the ongoing story of God's work in the world. This is a vision of biblical faithfulness that values both conviction and charity.

Week 4 | The holy catholic church | 1 Corinthians 12:12–27, Ephesians 4:1–16

Paul's vision of the Church as one body affirms unity without uniformity. Faith is lived through mutual care, shared mission, and common belonging.

Methodism did not begin as a church, but as a movement within the Church. Wesley never intended to create a separate denomination, and he believed deeply in the unity of Christ's body.

This week explores what it means to confess belief in the holy catholic church, not as a rejection of denominational identity, but as a reminder that the Church is larger than any single tradition. We will reflect on connectionalism, accountability, and the belief that faith is lived best in community.

To be Methodist is to belong, not just to a local congregation, but to a wider body bound together in Christ.

Week 5 | Mystery | Romans 11:33–36, 1 Corinthians 13:9–12

After extended theological argument, Paul ends in doxology. God's wisdom exceeds human comprehension and calls forth humility rather than control.

Wesley held strong convictions, but he also knew the limits of human understanding. Not everything about God can be explained, categorized, or resolved.

This week explores the Wesleyan commitment to theological humility. We will consider why mystery is not a weakness of faith but one of its strengths. In a world that demands certainty and quick answers, Wesleyan theology makes room for wonder, reverence, and faithful disagreement.

Mystery keeps us curious, grounded, and dependent on grace.

Week 6 | Why It Matters | James 2:14–26, Matthew 25:31–46

James insists that faith must take visible form. Belief that does not shape action is incomplete.

Theology is never just an intellectual exercise. For Wesley, right belief was always connected to right living. Grace leads to transformation. Scripture leads to obedience. Sacraments lead to service. Theology matters because lives, neighbors, and communities matter.

Discipleship isn't a program—it's a lifelong journey. As we close the series, we invite everyone to take the next step in faith by joining a new Group.

Week 1 – Outward and Visible

Scripture: Acts 2:37–47; Matthew 28:16–20

Scripture Summary

Acts 2 describes the earliest Christian community responding to the gospel through repentance, baptism, shared life, prayer, teaching, and the breaking of bread. These practices are not presented as symbols alone but as formative actions through which God shapes a people. Matthew 28 frames baptism as part of Jesus' enduring command, binding discipleship to embodied practice in the life of the Church.

Sermon Overview

This sermon explores the Wesleyan understanding of sacraments as outward and visible signs of inward and spiritual grace. In this tradition, baptism and communion are not merely symbolic reminders but means through which God actively works. God uses ordinary elements to communicate extraordinary grace.

John Wesley described the sacraments as “means of grace,” practices through which God's love meets us again and again. This sermon will emphasize that sacraments are communal, embodied, and rooted in God's initiative rather than human worthiness.

Supplementary ideas and voices:

- Wesley's sermons on the means of grace
- Early Church practices as described in Acts
- The idea that faith is something we practice, not only profess

Discussion Questions

1. What stands out to you about how the early church lived its faith in Acts 2?
2. How have you experienced baptism or communion shaping your faith over time?
3. Why do you think God chooses ordinary elements like water, bread, and wine?
4. How might understanding sacraments as means of grace change how we approach them?
5. What does it mean for faith to be embodied rather than only believed?

Additional Scripture for the Week

- Romans 6:3–11, 1 Corinthians 10:16–17, John 6:35–58, Colossians 2:11–15, Exodus 12:1–14

Week 2 – Grace

Scripture: Ephesians 2:1–10; Luke 15:11–32

Scripture Summary

Ephesians 2 traces a movement from spiritual death to new life, emphasizing that salvation is God's gift, not human achievement. Luke 15's parable of the prodigal son reveals grace as both forgiveness and restoration, offered before repentance is fully articulated and extended beyond what seems reasonable.

Sermon Overview

This sermon names grace as the foundation of Wesleyan theology. Grace precedes us, meets us in our brokenness, and continues shaping us throughout our lives. Wesley spoke of prevenient, justifying, and sanctifying grace not as rigid stages, but as a way of describing God's ongoing action.

Grace is not merely pardon for sin. It is God's persistent work of healing, renewal, and transformation. This sermon will emphasize that salvation is both a moment and a lifelong journey.

Supplementary ideas and voices:

- Wesley's emphasis on grace before human response
- Salvation as relational rather than transactional
- Holiness as love perfected over time

Discussion Questions

1. Where do you see God's initiative at work in these passages?
2. How does the parable of the prodigal challenge common ideas about fairness?
3. In what ways have you experienced grace as something ongoing rather than past?
4. Why do you think people struggle to receive grace freely?
5. How might grace shape the way we treat others?

Additional Scripture for the Week

- Titus 3:3–8, Romans 5:1–11, John 1:14–18, Psalm 103, Philippians 1:3–6

Week 3 – The Bible

Scripture: Luke 24:13–35; 2 Timothy 3:14–17

Scripture Summary

On the road to Emmaus, the risen Christ interprets Scripture in a way that reveals God’s redemptive story rather than isolated prooftexts. 2 Timothy affirms Scripture’s role in teaching and formation, grounding faith in a text that shapes character and community.

Sermon Overview

This sermon explores how Wesleyans read the Bible as primary, but not isolated. Scripture is interpreted in conversation with tradition, reason, and lived experience. Wesley valued the authority of Scripture while rejecting rigid or weaponized readings.

The Bible is presented as a means of grace that forms disciples and draws communities into God’s ongoing story.

Supplementary ideas and voices:

- Wesley’s “man of one book” statement understood holistically
- Scripture as formation, not just information
- Communal reading and interpretation

Discussion Questions

1. What do you notice about how Jesus uses Scripture on the road to Emmaus?
2. How has Scripture shaped your faith beyond providing answers?
3. Why is community important when interpreting the Bible?
4. What challenges arise when Scripture is treated as a weapon?
5. How can Scripture lead us toward love of God and neighbor?

Additional Scripture for the Week

- Psalm 119:97–105, Hebrews 4:12–13, Nehemiah 8:1–12, John 5:39–40, Deuteronomy 6:4–9

Week 4 – The Holy Catholic Church

Scripture: 1 Corinthians 12:12–27; Ephesians 4:1–16

Scripture Summary

Paul describes the Church as one body made up of many members, each dependent on the others. Unity is not sameness but shared life and purpose. The Church grows as each part contributes to the whole.

Sermon Overview

This sermon explores Wesleyan connectionalism and the belief that faith is lived best in community. Methodism emerged as a movement within the broader Church, grounded in accountability, shared mission, and mutual care.

Belief in the holy catholic church affirms that God’s work extends beyond any single congregation or tradition.

Supplementary ideas and voices:

- Early Methodist class meetings
- Accountability as a gift rather than control
- The Church as a sign of God’s reconciling work

Discussion Questions

1. What images of the Church stand out to you in these passages?
2. Why is faith difficult to live in isolation?
3. How does belonging shape belief?
4. What responsibilities come with being part of the Church?
5. How might connection strengthen mission?

Additional Scripture for the Week

- Acts 2:42–47, Romans 12:3–8, John 17:20–23, Colossians 3:12–17, Hebrews 10:23–25

Week 5 – Mystery

Scripture: Romans 11:33–36; 1 Corinthians 13:9–12

Scripture Summary

Paul concludes deep theological reflection not with answers but with praise. Human knowledge is partial, and full understanding belongs to God alone. Faith involves humility and trust in what cannot be fully grasped.

Sermon Overview

This sermon explores theological humility in the Wesleyan tradition. Wesley held convictions while acknowledging the limits of human understanding. Mystery is not a failure of faith but a posture of reverence.

The sermon invites space for wonder, disagreement, and faithful restraint in a culture that demands certainty.

Supplementary ideas and voices:

- Wesley’s “Catholic Spirit” approach - “Though we cannot think alike, may we not love alike? May we not be of one heart, though we are not of one opinion?”
- Doxology as theology’s proper response
- Faith as trust rather than control

Discussion Questions

1. Why do you think Paul ends in worship rather than explanation?
2. Where do you struggle with mystery in your faith?
3. How can humility deepen belief?
4. Why is certainty often appealing?
5. How can mystery strengthen community rather than divide it?

Additional Scripture for the Week

- Job 38–42 (selected), Isaiah 55:8–9, Psalm 131, Ecclesiastes 3:1–11, Deuteronomy 29:29

Week 6 – Why It Matters

Scripture: James 2:14–26; Matthew 25:31–46

Scripture Summary

James insists that faith is revealed through action. Matthew 25 portrays judgment rooted in lived compassion toward the vulnerable. Belief and practice are inseparable.

Sermon Overview

This final sermon draws the series together by emphasizing lived faith. Wesley rejected belief disconnected from action, insisting that holiness expresses itself through love of neighbor.

Theology matters because it shapes lives, communities, and witness.

Supplementary ideas and voices:

- Wesley's emphasis on social holiness
- Discipleship as formation over time
- Faith expressed through mercy and justice

Discussion Questions

1. How do these passages challenge purely intellectual faith?
2. What does lived faith look like in everyday life?
3. Where do belief and practice drift apart?
4. How does theology shape compassion?
5. What might your next step in discipleship be?

Additional Scripture for the Week

- Micah 6:6–8
- Romans 12:9–21
- Luke 10:25–37
- Galatians 5:6
- 1 John 3:16–18